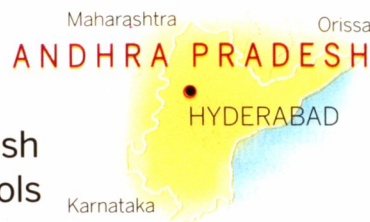


The Clay Way

Battling state laws, a campaign in Andhra Pradesh inspires people to craft eco-friendly Ganesha idols



THE 12-FEET GANESHA IDOL MADE FROM MACHILIPATNAM CLAY

By Amarnath K. Menon

Environmental awareness is going the religious way, with Lord Ganesha beginning to preside over his birthday festivities in an ecologically benign manner. Many of the idols to be immersed in water at the end of the birthday celebrations, earlier made of plaster of paris (POP) and coated with harmful chemical paints, are being made of clay now. But the irony is that while the Central Pollution Control Board (CPCB) promotes clay and natural products, Andhra Pradesh has an official order advocating the use of POP.

To counter water pollution through chemicals like cadmium, mercury, arsenic, lead, chromium and nickel, found in the paints on POP idols, the Centre for Environment Education, the Andhra Pradesh Pollution Control Board and the Andhra Pradesh National Green Corps (APNGC) have been running a campaign to promote clay idols. Schoolchildren and teachers who attend these eco-friendly workshops, that begin after the Independence Day and conclude just before the festival, have persuaded parents to use clay idols instead of POP idols.

"Children love to work with clay. We talk about envi-

ronmental issues and link these to culture and tradition. This includes promoting concern for clean water bodies and green plantations," explains W.G. Prasanna Kumar, director, APNGC. The tenuous links that exist between the soil, water bodies where the idols are immersed and the 21 types of plants required for the puja are explained to children. They are also told about the adverse impact of chemical pollutants as these enter the food chain.

Training potters and clay idol competitions have helped promote the campaign as more people are seeking clay idols. The Tree Guard Foundation (TGF), Hyderabad, has given away 50,000 clay idols after enlisting 20 workers to make them. It also installed a 12-ft idol of the elephant god with clay brought from the port town of Machilipatnam. "This is to demonstrate that large idols can be made with clay," says TGF founder president Dora Raju. Now idols are being made from coconut shells and natural pigments like turmeric are being used.

For the moment, potters are happy while those making POP idols for public places too are not worried. The eco-warriors aren't popping the bubbly. Yet.